

“ WHEN ALL LONGINGS THAT ARE IN THE HEART VANISH, THEN A MORTAL BECOMES IMMORTAL... ”

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Iron rapidly replaced bronze in tools and weapons, signaling the end of the **Bronze Age**.

In Mesoamerica, the region's first great civilization, the **Olmec**, was emerging in the lowlands of Mexico's southern Gulf coast. The Olmecs built ceremonial centers, including San Lorenzo, constructed temples and houses on earthen mounds, and carved huge stone

heads clad in helmets. They also established long-distance trade routes. Meanwhile, **other cultures** were **emerging**, such as at Cerro Sechin, in what is now Peru.

Stone warrior

Monumental carvings from temples at Cerro Sechin on the Peruvian coast show warriors, torture victims, and human sacrifices.



THE CLOSE OF THE 2ND MILLENNIUM SAW MAJOR CHANGES in the power politics of West Asia. In 1070 BCE, the Egyptian New Kingdom ended and Egypt entered a time of unrest called the **Third Intermediate Period**, which lasted until 747 BCE (see 800–700 BCE). Historians believe that the power of the pharaohs had been eroded by a priestly elite who had gained control of many areas. By 1000 BCE, all of the territories won by New Kingdom pharaohs had been lost.

In **Mesopotamia**, there were **frequent wars** between the Babylonians, Assyrians, and Elamites; the region was also subjected to devastating raids by Aramaean nomads from the west.

Meanwhile, other powers were rising in the region. A Semitic-speaking people, who called themselves **Canaanites**, had inhabited the Levant for centuries, living in city-states that controlled the surrounding territory. They were skilled seafarers and played a major role in international trade. By 1100 BCE, Canaanite port cities such as Arwad, Byblos, Tyre, and Sidon were expanding their operations, establishing trading posts and colonies throughout the eastern Mediterranean. They traded cedarwood from Lebanon, glass- and ivory-ware, metal ores, and, most important, an expensive purple dye made from murex shellfish. It was this luxury commodity that caused them to be known by their more familiar Greek name, the **Phoenicians**, after *phoinix*, Greek for “purple.”

In China, a new dynasty replaced the Shang in 1027 BCE, when King Wu of the Zhou defeated the last Shang ruler, Di-Xin. The **Zhou dynasty** was to **rule China for 700 years**. This long era is usually divided into two periods: the Western and Eastern Zhou. During the first era, the Zhou capital was Zongzhou. This was a **time of prosperity** and strong central control. Zhou territory was divided into fiefs held by trusted noblemen, in return for military allegiance. But many aspects of Chinese tradition already present in the Shang period continued in the Zhou, including ancestor worship and the use of oracle bones for divination.

Meanwhile, in Japan, the **Jomon culture**, named after the cord patterns (*jomon*) that decorate its pottery, continued. The Jomon people were still hunter-gatherers, albeit prosperous and sedentary.

In northern India, small groups of nomadic pastoralists had been migrating into the **Ganges basin** from Central Asia since the 1500s BCE. By the 1100s BCE, most had begun to **settle and cultivate crops**. They spoke **Sanskrit**, which became the language of early Indian

sacred writings. Sanskrit, an Indo-European language related to Iranian and almost all European languages, is also the ancestor of modern languages such as Hindi and Urdu.

Sacred writings called the **Vedas** were transmitted orally in Sanskrit for many centuries. Although the Vedas are largely religious writings and hymns, the geographical information that they contain not only describes the gradual spread of farmers and pastoralists from the Punjab to the Ganges basin, but also gives some information about conflicts with other groups, and local life at the time. For example, the **division of society** into **varnas** or **castes** is described in the Vedas, first appearing in Book X of *Rigveda*, although there is nothing in the text to suggest that the system was hereditary at the time.



Mark of a culture

In this example of late-Jomon pottery, the bowl and stand bear the distinctive rope patterns that give the Jomon period its name.

c. 1100 BCE Mycenaean period ends and Dark Age of Greece begins

1069 BCE Start of Third Intermediate Period in Egypt

1027 BCE King Wu claims Shang king has forfeited Mandate of Heaven to rule

1006 BCE David succeeds Saul as king of the Hebrews (Israelites)

c. 1000 BCE Phoenicians establish colonies and ports around the Mediterranean